

came along with his monies? Well, over 80 per cent of Twitter stock was held by private firms and investment funds in early March 2022.

So was Twitter truly bound to be accountable to the people? Nope. And the fact is that nothing much has changed. Instead of a lot more investors, we now have fewer investors. The general public never really had much of a say before and they'll not have much of a say now either.

ELON MUSK, THE PERSON

Source: Wikimedia Commons



Living a very public life, Elon Musk is inarguably the most transparent CEO of a trillion-dollar company. The man wears his

heart on his sleeve and you don't need to be part of his inner circle to know what his thoughts really are. All you need to do is open up his Twitter profile and he'll have vomited out his innermost thoughts even before he has had his first cuppa. If at all, it can be argued that Elon Musk is a little too transparent. He has, after all, gotten into trouble multiple times over the years for this very fact. The SEC (U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission) went after him because of one of his tweets regarding funding for taking Tesla private. Recently, it was discovered that Elon Musk wasn't in the wrong but was forced to apologise because a public statement was not made by his partners.

He is also transparent and open to journalists. In an era where practically every piece of information about business owners is carefully crafted by an army of PR consultants, Elon is a far cry from the rest of the tech billionaires. Kara Swisher, a prominent technology journalist who has been covering silicon valley technology giants since 1994, in an interview with James D. Walsh of the *Intelligencer* had this to say about Musk, "He's obviously a visionary. I prefer dealing with him to others because he gives you genuine answers. He will call you back. He will have a beef with you when others run

away because they're cowardly. If he disagrees, he'll be in your face, but at least he's in your face. I'm perfectly fine with that. In a world where everybody's making a lot of silly stuff, he's not. Cars, rockets, solar, these are important things. He can't be as silly or as fascist as people make him out to be. Maybe he does act like a stupid tech bro sometimes, but maybe he's a little more complex than that? Thomas Edison was not a nice man. Many inventors were very difficult, problematic people — Steve Jobs, for example. The times we live in are so reductive that it's really hard to be able to get our minds around a truly complex human being. And that's what he is."

THE REAL CHANGES

We really don't know what's going to happen with Twitter after Elon Musk finishes the acquisition. A lot of this has to do with regulations that prevent information from being made public during an acquisition deal such as this. Both sides, the sellers and the buyers, are expected to keep mum and follow the due processes set down by the regulatory body. That being said, Elon Musk in all his transparency has put down some plans for Twitter. The first is that the algorithm will be made open source. We don't know if the actual codebase is being made openly accessible or just the algorithm will be made public. Actual code would make it easier for security researchers to poke and prod through the code to find out vulnerabilities which would have otherwise remained secret or known to just a few bad actors. Sure, it does make the code more vulnerable but there are obfuscation methods that can be utilised to mitigate the risks by some factor. While making the code open-source is one thing, there's the fact that most major tech platforms heavily rely on AI (Artificial Intelligence) models to make mincemeat of repetitive tasks. These AI models are inherently black boxes which can't be made open and it takes a lot of effort to identify if the AI models have inherent or learned biases. Once made public, security researchers will be able to implement the current

production model and feed it sample data to identify biases if any. This too goes towards making the platform more open and equal.

Musk also has monetisation plans for tweets. Corporates and institutions will be forced to pony up money for using the platform while normal users will continue to enjoy the free service as it currently exists. This way, the platform which hasn't grown or scaled in quite some time will have a shot in the arm to grow.

More Government control seems to be an obvious fallout of the proposed free speech changes since Elon Musk has very clearly stated that his stance on free speech is everything that matches the law. Countries like the US have a very liberal definition of free speech whereas countries such as China, Belarus and South Sudan have extremely restrictive



laws. So Twitter can have geo-fencing laws that prevent certain tweets and accounts from being visible in countries with stringent restrictions whereas the same will be openly accessible in more liberal countries. Such measures have been in place for more than a decade on most social platforms so it's nothing new for Twitter to implement.

IT'S HIS TURN

Say what you will about Elon Musk, the simple truth is that he can build better products than most of his contemporaries. From payment processors to electric cars to space crafts to satellites, the visionary billionaire has the drive and intelligence to make things happen. It's now his turn to take a crack at making Twitter a truly open and accommodating platform. 